FOOD & DRINK

PROFILE



A ROOM WITH RAMEN

How Neha Mishra turned her ramen obsession into Kinoya, the top ranked restaurant of the UAE and no 2 in Middle East and North Africa's 50 best list.

Amin Ali

Long before Kinoya became one of Dubai's landmark restaurants, Neha Mishra was simply trying to understand a bowl of ramen. There was no grand culinary plan behind it. No restaurant blueprint. No chef's training. And definitely no Japanese connection or background.

At the time, Mishra was working in a creative production house, building a career in advertising and photography-led projects. She had spent years enabling other people's ideas, but somewhere along the way, she found herself craving a creative outlet of her own. That outlet arrived in the form of ramen, a dish she had heard was layered, nuanced and notoriously difficult to master.

What began as curiosity; a personal pursuit, soon became an obsession. Mishra started making ramen for herself in 2016, documenting her journey online through an Instagram page called A Story of Food. The account was never conceived as a business tool. It was, by her own account, an almost incognito creative alias, a space where she could experiment freely without pressure.

She had heard ramen might look simple, but it was nuanced and a complex dish to make. She started to make it and realised how difficult it was to make. In the beginning, she jokes, she was making plenty of bad ramen, learning by trial, error and relentless repetition. But the very difficulty of the dish drew her in further.

Ramen, she discovered, was not just a recipe. It was a world. From broths and noodles to oils, tare and toppings, every component demanded study and patience. Unlike more codified culinary forms, ramen offered few straightforward rules. It was contemporary, yet deeply rooted, freestyle yet exacting. The best ramen masters rarely gave much away. So Mishra had to do what all serious obsessions demand. She immersed herself. She travelled to Japan, visited markets, sourced ingredients, ate widely and studied the dish layer by layer until its language began to make sense to her.

That pursuit, despite being deeply personal, was being shared online. And the internet was paying attention. Followers began gravitating not just towards